

Thursday, 16 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Overcast 29° 18°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 28° 14°	MANCHESTER Overcast 28° 15°	GLASGOW Overcast 25° 13°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

Reform UK has unveiled a new £100m security plan for MPs, following the tragic death of party spokeswoman Ann Widdecombe.

Police confirmed Ms Widdecombe was killed in a 'targeted attack' earlier this week. The proposed 'round-the-clock' security measures aim to better protect elected officials. This comes amid increasing concerns for the safety of those in public life.

POLITICS · UK
- 2

Incoming Prime Minister Andy Burnham says a full review of MP security is urgently needed, following the death of Ann Widdecombe.

Mr Burnham stated that politics has 'darkened' significantly in the decade since he was last in Westminster. His comments underscore the growing anxiety about the safety of politicians. This review will be a priority for the new government.

POLITICS · UK
- 3

A man has been arrested in south London on suspicion of sending threatening communications to an MP.

The Met Police confirmed the man in his 20s was held this week. The arrest relates to a social media post that allegedly threatened to shoot Farage. This follows heightened concerns over the safety of public figures.

CRIME · UK
- 4

The family of a British man jailed in Iran says his sentence has been extended by two years.

Craig Foreman's relatives claim the additional punishment is for speaking to the media from prison. This development highlights the ongoing challenges faced by British nationals detained abroad. His family continues to campaign for his release.

FOREIGN AFFAIRS · UK
- 5

The UK continues to bask in an exceptional heatwave, with persistent 30C temperatures and record sunshine.

Many areas have seen double the usual sunshine hours for this time of year. Forecasters say the hot, dry conditions are set to continue. This prolonged spell of warm weather is delighting some, but raising concerns for others.

WEATHER · UK

What's coming up

- 1 Big Brother host Will Best is the latest celebrity to be confirmed for the new series of Strictly Come Dancing!**

He's the sixth star announced for the popular dance competition. Fans will be eager to see how the TV presenter fares on the dancefloor. It promises to be another exciting series!

| ON AIR – Do you think Will Best has what it takes to win the Glitterball trophy?

TV · COMING UP
- 2 Ed Sheeran is inspiring a new government-backed scheme to bring music rehearsal spaces and studios into local libraries.**

The pop superstar will help design the programme, aiming to boost local music talent. It's a fantastic initiative to make music more accessible for everyone. Imagine discovering the next Ed Sheeran in your local library!

| ON AIR – What do you think of libraries becoming music hubs? Would you use one?

MUSIC · FUTURE
- 3 The Cheetah Girls are making a comeback, and a British teen has beaten 300,000 competitors to join the new generation!**

The iconic girl group is being revived with fresh talent. This young star has landed a dream role, following a massive open audition process. It's a huge opportunity for her!

| ON AIR – Are you excited for the return of The Cheetah Girls? Do you remember the originals?

MUSIC · COMING UP
- 4 Music fans are buzzing about who should be inducted into a proposed Scottish Rock and Roll Hall of Fame.**

Some of Scotland's biggest music names are supporting the bid to create this new institution. It aims to celebrate the rich history of Scottish music. It's a great way to honour legendary artists!

| ON AIR – Who do you think absolutely *has* to be in the Scottish Rock and Roll Hall of Fame?

MUSIC · FUTURE
- 5 The state of California is leading a lawsuit to block the proposed mega-merger between Paramount and Warner Bros.**

California, where both studios are headquartered, has joined 11 other states in the action. This could have huge implications for the film industry. It's a big move to prevent a media giant from forming.

| ON AIR – Do you think these huge studio mergers are good or bad for film fans?

FILM · FUTURE

On the schedule

1 **Wayne Rooney has declared Jude Bellingham the best player at the World Cup so far, and believes Harry Kane can destroy Argentina.**

As England prepare for their semi-final clash, Rooney's confidence in the team is clear. He thinks Bellingham's performances have been outstanding. It's a huge vote of confidence from an England legend!

ON AIR – Do you agree with Rooney that Bellingham is the player of the tournament so far?

FOOTBALL · UK

2 **England are gearing up to face Norway in the World Cup quarter-finals in Miami, and fans can relive all their goals so far.**

Thomas Tuchel's side has had an impressive run to get to this stage. Supporters will be hoping for more goals and another victory. The excitement for the next match is building!

ON AIR – What's been your favourite England goal of the World Cup so far?

FOOTBALL · UK

3 **The half-time break in Sunday's World Cup final is expected to be extended, lasting up to 25 minutes.**

This is longer than usual, giving players more time to recover and broadcasters more time for analysis. It's a slight change that could impact the game. What will the teams do with the extra time?

ON AIR – Do you like the idea of a longer half-time in the World Cup final, or is it too long?

FOOTBALL · GLOBAL

4 **England suffered a comfortable defeat against India in the first one-day international, going 1-0 down in the series.**

They struggled to recover from an early collapse, losing five wickets for just 19 runs. India cruised to a six-wicket victory at Edgbaston. England will need to bounce back quickly in the next match.

ON AIR – Can England turn this ODI series around after a tough start against India?

CRICKET · UK

5 **Confident Scot Robert MacIntyre is eyeing Open Championship glory as he tees up at Royal Birkdale.**

Scotland's number one golfer believes he's a much-improved player since his first Open in 2019. He's hoping to make a big impact in this year's tournament. Could this be his year?

ON AIR – Do you think Robert MacIntyre has a real chance at winning The Open this year?

GOLF · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new study suggests that the simple act of 'watching a sunrise' can significantly boost your mood and productivity for the day.**
Researchers found that exposure to natural morning light and the quiet contemplation of a sunrise helps reset circadian rhythms and fosters a sense of calm before the daily rush begins. Many participants reported feeling more focused and less stressed.
- 2 The delightful trend of 'decorating your garden shed' is blooming across the country.**
No longer just for tools, sheds are being transformed into charming mini-retreats, home offices, or creative studios, often adorned with fairy lights, quirky signs, and colourful planting schemes. It's all about making the most of outdoor spaces.
- 3 Experts are encouraging us to rediscover the joy of 'writing postcards' instead of sending quick texts.**
The thoughtful process of choosing a card, writing a personal message, and mailing it creates a more meaningful connection. Recipients often cherish postcards as tangible memories, unlike fleeting digital messages.
- 4 The surprising popularity of 'board game cafes' is growing, offering a refreshing alternative to traditional pubs.**
These welcoming venues provide a vast selection of classic and modern board games, alongside refreshments, creating a relaxed social environment for friends and families to connect away from screens.
- 5 A recent survey highlights that many of us are finding solace in 'collecting interesting pebbles' during walks.**
It's a simple, mindful activity that encourages close observation of nature and provides a tangible collection of memories from outdoor adventures. Some even paint or display their finds.
- 6 The charming custom of 'leaving positive notes' in public places is subtly spreading smiles.**
Whether tucked into library books, on park benches, or inside coffee shop sleeves, these anonymous messages offer words of encouragement or simple affirmations, brightening someone's day unexpectedly.
- 7 There's a growing appreciation for the therapeutic benefits of 'listening to the rain fall'.**
Many are seeking out specific audio recordings or simply opening a window to enjoy the natural white noise of rainfall, finding it incredibly soothing for relaxation, meditation, or even aiding sleep.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 70% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what with our houseplants when no one's looking, even if we know they can't understand us?

ANSWER: TALKING TO THEM, TELLING THEM ABOUT OUR DAY!

Q Our survey said that over 65% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before making a big decision, like wiggling their toes or tapping their fingers?

ANSWER: A SPECIFIC NERVOUS FIDGET OR 'GOOD LUCK' GESTURE!

TALK TOPIC

- We all have those 'unusual items' that we've kept for years, tucked away in a drawer or a box, perhaps for sentimental reasons or just because we can't bear to part with them.

What's the strangest or most surprising item you still have knocking about, and why do you keep it?

- Think about those 'little sounds' that are so specific to a particular place or time of day, like the morning birdsong through an open window or the distant chime of an ice cream van in summer.

What's a sound that instantly transports you to a happy memory or a favourite place, and what makes it so special?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Did you know that a group of owls is called a 'parliament'?

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** The fictional 'hover-cat' was once a popular pet among Victorian inventors, known for its ability to float slightly above the ground due to static electricity.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£25 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.8 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- A cloud can weigh more than a million pounds.
- The world's quietest room is located at Microsoft's headquarters in Washington state, where the background noise is negative decibels.
- Butterflies taste with their feet.
- Mount Everest grows by a few millimetres each year due to geological uplift.
- The shortest war in history lasted only 38 to 45 minutes between Britain and Zanzibar in 1896.
- The average person walks the equivalent of five times around the world in their lifetime.
- Flamingos are not born pink; their feathers turn pink from the beta-carotene in their diet of brine shrimp and algae.
- The 'richest' library in the world, in terms of its collection, is the Library of Congress in Washington D.C.

On this day

Day 197 of the year, 168 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: André de Soveral; Christian feast day: Gondulphus of Tongeren; Christian feast day: Helier; Christian feast day: Blessed Irmgard of Chiemsee. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1956 — Tony Kushner, American playwright and screenwriter
- 1927 — Derek Hawsworth, English footballer (died 2021)
- 1934 — Denise LaSalle, American singer-songwriter and producer (died 2018)
- 1928 — Anita Brookner, English novelist and art historian (died 2016)
- 1987 — AnnaLynne McCord, American actress and producer
- 1971 — Ed Kowalczyk, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1996 — Kevin Abstract, American rapper and singer-songwriter
- 1957 — Faye Grant, American actress

THE DAY TODAY

- 1990 — The Parliament of the Ukrainian SSR declares state sovereignty over the territory of the Ukrainian SSR.
- 1979 — Iraqi President Ahmed Hassan al-Bakr resigns and is replaced by Saddam Hussein.
- 2009 — Teoh Beng Hock, an aide to a politician in Malaysia is found dead on the rooftop of a building adjacent to the offices of the Anti-Corruption Commission, sparking an inquest that gains nationwide attention.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 2015 — Four U.S. Marines and a United States Navy Sailor are killed in the a shooting spree targeting military installations in Chattanooga, Tennessee.
- 1983 — Sikorsky S-61 disaster: A helicopter crashes off the Isles of Scilly, causing 20 fatalities.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1948 — Following token resistance, the city of Nazareth, revered by Christians as the hometown of Jesus, capitulates to Israeli troops during Operation Dekel in the 1948 Arab–Israeli War.
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1948 — The storming of the cockpit of the Miss Macao passenger seaplane, operated by a subsidiary of the Cathay Pacific Airways, marks the first aircraft hijacking of a commercial plane.

- 2019 — A 100-year-old building in Mumbai, India, collapses, killing at least 10 people and leaving many others trapped.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 198 of the year, 167 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Alexius of Rome (Western Church); Christian feast day: Andrew Zorard; Christian feast day: Cynehelm; Christian feast day: Cynllo. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1985 — Neil McGregor, Scottish footballer
- 1979 — Mike Vogel, American actor
- 1954 — J. Michael Straczynski, American author, screenwriter, and producer
- 1952 — Nicolette Larson, American singer-songwriter (died 1997)
- 1963 — Regina Belle, American singer-songwriter, producer, and actress
- 1976 — Luke Bryan, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1939 — Spencer Davis, Welsh singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2020)
- 1941 — Bob Taylor, English cricketer

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1938 — Douglas Corrigan takes off from Brooklyn to fly the "wrong way" to Ireland and becomes known as "Wrong Way" Corrigan.
- 1962 — Nuclear weapons testing: The "Small Boy" test shot Little Feller I becomes the last atmospheric test detonation at the Nevada National Security Site.
- 1976 — The opening of the Summer Olympics in Montreal is marred by 25 African teams boycotting the games because of New Zealand's participation. Contrary to rulings by other international sports organizations, the IOC had declined to exclude New Zealand because of their participation...

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1997 — After takeoff from Husein Sastranegara International Airport, Sempati Air Flight 304 crashes into a residential neighborhood in Bandung, killing 28 people.
- 1717 — King George I of Great Britain sails down the River Thames with a barge of 50 musicians, where George Frideric Handel's Water Music is premiered.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)